Three Years of Hurt, A Lifetime of Love

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/36057871.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra)

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by Guardian_Rose

Summary

She sighs, turning away from the sunlight filtering in through the small window. The silence of the late morning is shattered by her scream.

Something crashes into pieces on the stone floor in the other room and then the bedroom door is slamming open.

“Shit!” Catra rushes to the bed and rolls a weeping Adora over again onto her back. “That was meant to keep you out for another couple hours. What the fuck kind of metabolism do you have?”

Adora is too busy fighting her own reflexive biting. If she bites through her bottom lip then Catra will be pissed. Never a good idea to piss a healer off.

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Tumblr Anon Prompt:

for a catradora prompt: catra is a herbalist that owns an apothecary and adora is a mage that keeps getting hurt/sick

Notes

Please, if you're sensitive to depictions of injuries, consider whether you wanna read this. I want y'all to stay safe!

Hi Anon! I know this is like maybe over a year late? But if you're still around, hope you enjoy!

For the prompt:

for a catradora prompt: catra is a herbalist that owns an apothecary and adora is a mage that keeps getting hurt/sick

See the end of the work for more notes

“Are you kidding me.”

It’s said so flatly, with no hint of an actual question to be detected, that Adora doesn’t even bother to look up at the herbalist. She pushes past her into the cottage instead, wincing as her dislocated arm brushes into the woman’s shoulder on the way by.

“I’ll pay you double, Catra, just set it and I’ll be on my way,” Adora says, hopping up onto a clear corner of the wooden table occupying the majority of the main room, she props her staff up against the table edge next to her but keeps a firm grip.

Various herbs and bundles of homegrown vegetables hand from string hung from the tops of the cupboard corners and the rafters. The kitchen sides, slightly cluttered with jars of medicinal ingredients and actual food, ring the right wall. The cupboards above are full of plates and bowls. *So* many bowls. Why would one single person, even a herbalist like Catra, need quite *that* many bowls?

Fingers snap in front of Adora’s face. Catra frowns at her; it borders on a sneer. Adora’s never sure if it’s meant to be truly as harsh as it comes across.

“Hit your head as well, Princess?”

“Not a princess.”

“Then stop wearing dresses into battle. It’s impractical.”

Catra stalks away before Adora can reply, opening and closing the lower cupboards with her tail whilst collecting strands of plants from above her head without looking.

“I wear trousers underneath,” Adora mutters, “and it’s just a long tunic, anyway. It’s not my fault it looks like a skirt because of my belt…”

A scoff sounds from where Catra has crouched down out of sight behind Adora but no reply is forthcoming.

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Adora wakes under a familiar blanket. Scratchy fabric mixed with the most expensive fabric. Stitches that are loose in places and tight to the point of nearly snapping in others. She sighs, turning away from the sunlight filtering in through the small window. The silence of the late morning is shattered by her scream.

Something crashes into pieces on the stone floor in the other room and then the bedroom door is slamming open.

" *Shit* !" Catra rushes to the bed and rolls a weeping Adora over again onto her back. "That was meant to keep you out for another couple hours. What the fuck kind of metabolism do you *have* ?"

Adora is too busy fighting her own reflexive biting. If she bites through her bottom lip then Catra will be pissed. Never a good idea to piss a healer off.

" *Fuck* ," said healer hisses, peeling back the bandages around Adora's upper chest to see…something. "Fucking fuck, Adora."

Catra tentatively touches the side of Adora's breast and the pain flares.

"Shit, sorry, sorry," Catra says softly, sounding genuinely concerned for once which has Adora's bleary mind picking up the pace in imagining the worst. "I have to disinfect this again. I-Whatever blade this was or spell must have some sort of posion element to it and I can't-"

Another scream rips its way up and out of Adora's lungs. Burning her throat. Her body reflexively tries to curl in on itself which only adds to the agony. There are tears streaming past her closed eyelids. Catra hauls her back again, leaning a significant amount of weight onto her shoulders. She's swearing again. Barely audible under the cacophony of Adora's whimpering cries.

She can’t even remember the fight. Can’t remember what she was fighting for. Who she was protecting. She can’t even remember the pain before falling and *that* is the most worrying part of all. Maybe it was a duel. Maybe that was how Catra was there to save her. To bring her back to her house of healing.

“I’m going to- I have to- *Fuck!* ”

Hair tickles Adora’s cheeks. Pressure lands gently against her forehead. Warm breath brushes across her lips. Catra’s nose brushes hers, just the tips. Adora takes a shuddery breath. Fighting to calm enough to reassure Catra that whatever she has to do, it’s okay. It’s okay. Do whatever has to be done. Catra shivers against her. And then she’s gone. Adora whimpers again, this time at the loss of comfort.

She returns with a whispered apology and a bitter, cold liquid being forced down her raw throat.

***

“Catra! Hi! I mean-”

“Do not bullshit me, Adora. I swear to the lands below, if you try and tell me that the medicine you’re about to request is for some poor unfortunate soul in some village ten leagues away so really you better get it and run…I *will* kill you,” Catra finishes her speech with a flat stare.

Adora winces. The woman can’t hide anything from her expression and she knows it.

Catra continues unperturbed, “and yes, you left your staff here last night.”

“Ah! Thanks, I wondered where that was!” Adora follows Catra into the cottage, bypassing the main room to follow her into the more private bedroom / library.

She spies her staff next to the spare pair of shoes she left behind last week and picks it up. When she turns back, Catra is standing in front of her with a nightshift held out. That same ‘do not argue with me’ look on her face. That same ‘I shouldn’t be so endeared by this’ affection in the warmth of her eyes.

“It’s midday,” Adora says, confused.

“You’re getting a cold.”

Adora tries to raise a singular eyebrow. Catra smirks in amusement at the attempt.

“I feel fine,” Adora says.

Catra raises a perfect, single eyebrow. Adora holds herself back from leaning across the gap to kiss the smirk off of her partner's lips.

"You're exhausted. Your balance is off. You, a *battle-mage* , left your *staff* here this morning. You have skipped the last three meals."

"I have not! I ate that bread Glimmer made last night! That was a meal!"

"That was three days ago."

"It was?"

Catra softens, dropping the nightshift over one of Adora's shoulders and gently tugging the staff away from her. "Yes, it was. So you, oh warrior princess, are going to have a nap and eat some stew."

"You made stew?"

"Scorpia made stew. I put some herbs in it to help ease any symptoms. Now, are we going to keep standing here debating this or can I go get us some lunch and you can doze whilst I read?"

Adora blushes a little at the idea of spending the whole day hidden away from the wider world, curled up with Catra in bed. This is still all so new to her, it makes her head light just to think that this is *hers* . That she *wants* this and she *knows* she wants this. Or maybe she is actually coming down with something.

***

Of course, it isn't all illness and battle wounds.

The majority of the time Adora does stay safe. Her barriers hold and her staff is as formidable as a sword and she comes home safe. Home safe to Catra, the woman who knows her body like it is her own. Maybe even better than her own, sometimes.

The ragged scar that crosses, deep like a valley, from Adora's left armpit to the natural dip between her breasts, slicing across the delicate tissues that Catra had had to clean endlessly. Over and over scraping away necrotic tissue. That had been the worst. Dislocations, broken bones, arrows still stuck in thighs, allergic reactions to nettles, all are better than that one month of Adora hanging between life and death. Only waking that once to scream and scream and *scream* . Catra still had nightmares. Her wife may carry the scar but she carries the memories. She'd rather her than Adora though so what else is there to say.

It isn't easy on either of them. Adora has a habit of throwing herself into reckless situations. Catra has a habit of impatience

when it comes to those she loves. She wants them safe and she wants them where she can see them.

They make it work.

They compromise and they shout at each other and they forgive each other and they change. They heal and they grow.

When they get married, Adora has a bruise along the right side of her jaw from a shithead teenage kid. Catra, to teach them a lesson in respect and hard work, takes them in as her apprentice. They learn. They soften. They become tougher and they become kinder. They become a family.

Adora doesn’t come home with blood in her blonde tresses anymore. Catra doesn’t hold on so tightly to ‘what ifs’ and stops watching for death in every step her family takes. Finn stops punching people on their wedding days.

End Notes

Thank you for reading! <3

No beta, all mistakes my own

Prompts welcome here and on my writing tumblr WordToTheRose or come say hi on my main Guarding-Rose

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!